

Cybercrime Type: Cyberbullying

Case Study: The Campaign Against a High School Student

In 2022, 15 year old Maya, a high school student in Mumbai, became the target of a sustained **cyberbullying** campaign. Cyberbullying involves the use of digital platforms social media, messaging apps, or gaming forums to harass, humiliate, or intimidate another person, often repeatedly and with malicious intent.

How It Happened:

1. **Origins:** A misunderstanding at school led a group of classmates to create a fake Instagram account using Maya's name and photos. They began posting embarrassing, doctored images.
2. **Amplification:** The bullies used WhatsApp groups to share private screenshots of Maya's old messages, adding mocking commentary. They encouraged peers to join in, rapidly expanding the audience.
3. **Escalation:** The harassment spilled into the real world. Anonymous "confession" pages on Instagram invited others to post hateful comments about her appearance and character. Maya was excluded from group chats and received hundreds of threatening direct messages.

Target & Consequences:

While **teenagers and young adults** are the most frequent targets, cyberbullying can affect anyone. The consequences for Maya were devastating. Her academic performance plummeted as she refused to attend school. She suffered from severe anxiety, depression, and social isolation. Even after the fake accounts were reported and removed, the psychological damage persisted. The anonymity and permanence of online attacks meant the humiliation followed her, highlighting how cyberbullying can destroy a victim's mental health, reputation, and sense of safety far more relentlessly than traditional bullying